objective measures, such as the amount of property they owned. It was often the most hard-working and efficient farmers who were stigmatised and expelled. In some villages local communists used the opportunity to get rid of their personal enemies. Some villages simply drew lots on who would be considered a kulak. Other villages held communal meetings to vote on the matter and often chose isolated farmers, widows, old people and other 'expendables' (exactly the sorts of people who in early modern Europe were most likely to be branded witches).[94]

The absurdity of the entire operation is manifested in the case of the Streletsky family from the Kurgan region of Siberia. Dmitry Streletsky, who was then a teenager, recalled years later how his family was branded kulaks and selected for liquidation. 'Serkov, the chairman of the village Soviet who deported us, explained: "I have received an order [from the district party committee] to find 17 kulak families for deportation. I formed a Committee of the Poor and we sat through the night to choose the families. There is no one in the village who is rich enough to qualify, and not many old people, so we simply chose the 17 families. You were chosen. Please don't take it personally. What else could I do?"'[95] If anyone dared object to the madness of the system, they were promptly denounced as kulaks and counter-revolutionaries and would themselves be liquidated.

Altogether, some five million kulaks would be expelled from their homes by 1933. As many as thirty thousand heads of households were shot. The more fortunate victims were resettled in their district of origin or became vagrant workers in the big cities, while about two million were either exiled to remote inhospitable regions or incarcerated as state slaves in labour camps.[96] Numerous important and notorious state projects – such as the construction of the White Sea Canal and the development of mines in the Arctic regions – were accomplished with the labour of millions of prisoners, many of them kulaks. It was one of the fastest and largest enslavement campaigns in human history.[97] Once branded a kulak, a person could not get rid of the stigma. Government agencies, party organs and secret police documents recorded who was a kulak in a labyrinthine system of *kartoteki* catalogues, archives and internal passports.

Kulak status even passed to the next generation, with devastating consequences. Kulak children were refused entrance to communist youth groups, the Red Army, universities and prestigious areas of employment.[98]